

NWSLL – 2026 AA Baseball Rules/Guidance

1. Pre-Game Meeting
 - a. Discuss all of the below items before the game.
2. Game Length
 - a. Recommendation is to not start a new inning after 1.5 hours, although coaches and umpires should agree beforehand.
 - i. **BUT** all can later agree to play one more inning if weather is good and the game is going well.
 - ii. **BUT** some fields have hard stops due to scheduling of other events later in evening (e.g., Lower Soundview)
3. Minimum Play
 - a. Minimum play is 9 defensive outs in a 6-inning game. For games less than 6 innings, minimum play is 6 defensive outs. It is REQUIRED that at least 3 of the defensive outs be in an infield position. (D8 Interleague Rule)
4. Pitching – The goal is to introduce kids to pitching and batting versus other kids, while instituting age-appropriate limitations to encourage kids to hit, encourage them to stay focused on defense, and keep the game moving.
 - a. Walks:
 - i. There will be no walks.
 - b. Coach Pitching:
 - i. If a batter takes Ball 4, the coach for the batter will coach-pitch the rest of the at-bat. The strike count is reset to zero. Coach pitches should be on a line, no lobs. Coaches are free to pitch in whatever fashion works for their players (i.e., pitch from a knee, pitch from closer in, etc.). There is no set distance from which a coach must pitch, **BUT** it should be no closer than halfway between the pitching rubber and home plate.
 1. Maximum of 4 pitches by the coach unless the 4th pitch is a foul ball (no limit on extra pitches if batter continues to foul off pitches, but a non-contact from the 4th pitch and later results in a strikeout). Every at-bat ends as a ball put in play or a strikeout **(which can happen in as few as 3 pitches, even from a coach)** with the exception of a batter that is hit by a pitch (See **Rule 5.b.** below).
 - c. Using the Portable Mound and Starting from the Pitching Rubber:
 - i. Players shall pitch using the portable mound, and the pitching distance for AA is 43 feet which is 3 feet forward of the AAA and Majors 46-foot

pitching rubber (D8 Interleague Rule). Place the portable mound appropriately.

- ii. Kid pitchers should pitch with a foot in contact with the pitching rubber, not one or more feet forward. When a portable mound is not used (due to a missing or damaged mound), if there are two pitching rubbers, the player may pitch off the forward rubber for safety reasons.
- d. Speeding Up Kid-Pitch Play:
 - i. **Optional Rule (if both coaches agree):** The coaches may station one bucket behind the pitcher's mound and one at the backstop. If the catcher catches or stops the ball in front of him/her, that ball is thrown back to the pitcher. If the ball passes the catcher, the catcher lets it go and a coach from pitching team collects ball and puts it in the bucket at backstop. The pitcher grabs a new ball from the bucket at the mound and pitches the next ball. Game moves MUCH quicker this way.

5. Hitting

- a. There is no on-deck area in the field of play where the next batter warms up (LL Green Book Rule). Further, the on-deck batter is not to be swinging a bat at all before hitting. This is a safety rule. Players may only take warm-up swings when they are actually up to bat.
 - b. **Optional Rule (if both coaches agree):** On a hit-by-pitch the batter has the choice of taking first base or continuing to bat.
6. Baserunning – The goal is to introduce base stealing, while instituting age-appropriate limitations, so innings do not fundamentally revolve around just base stealing as the only way to advance runners. This will also give the kids a more realistic preview of what games will feel like at the older levels when pitchers and catchers are more developed and discourage bad baserunning habits that may work at this age, but will not be successful at older levels.
- a. **On overthrows in the infield that hit the fence and stay in the infield dirt (e.g., at first or third base), the baserunner should stop at the base they were advancing toward. This is in alignment with Rule 6.b. below.**
 - b. On hits to the outfield or overthrows that go into the outfield grass, baserunners should stop advancing once the ball crosses the grass/dirt line and enters the infield, even if not yet under player control. If a baserunner has rounded a base and has committed to advancing to the next base, the baserunner may finish going to that base, at the risk of being tagged out. This rule rewards outfielders for quickly getting the ball back into the infield, which is the desired goal.
 - c. No leadoffs. Baserunners may not leave a base until the ball crosses home plate (LL Green Book Rule).

- d. No stealing of home at any time.
- e. No stealing on a dropped ball/errant throw on the return to the pitcher.
 - i. **BUT** do teach your catcher to step forward to throw the ball back and your pitcher to step forward 10-15 feet to receive the throw. This practice will save game time and better prepare them for future AAA play.
- f. No delayed steals (i.e., taking off right when catcher throws ball back to pitcher).
- g. Stealing of 2B or 3B is allowed all season, but only in this situation:
 - i. A passed ball or wild pitch that gets past the catcher (**which by definition means the runner cannot start to steal until it is past the catcher**). "Past the catcher" is defined as the ball getting past the catcher and going toward the backstop behind the catcher. A pitch that is blocked in front of, or next to, the catcher is not "past the catcher."
 - 1. **BUT** stealing is limited to 3 times per inning (double steals count as 2 steals)
- h. Base stealing is limited to a single base per baserunner. We want to encourage catchers to make the throw and fielders to defend a steal, so this rule is to ensure that there is no penalty for this important development.

7. Fielding

- a. If a team has only 7 or 8 players at game start, the other team shall provide an additional outfielder (or two) to the opponent for defensive purposes only (i.e., that player still hits for his own team) (D8 Interleague Rule).
- b. After Ball 4 and a coach enters to pitch to the batter, the kid pitcher shall play a defensive position within 3 feet of either side of the pitching rubber and not be in front of or behind the rubber. We do not want the pitcher to become an unfair 5th infielder playing the deep middle and making it hard for batters to hit a ball through the infield.
- c. Optional Rule (if both coaches agree): If the opposing coaches agree, a 10th player can play a 4th outfield position. This is highly encouraged as it limits the number of players sitting out on defense.
- d. There is no Infield Fly Rule for AA Baseball (D8 Interleague Rules).

8. Scoring

- a. The 5-run rule (5.07) is in effect for the entirety of the game, except for the sixth inning or last declared inning (for a shortened game due to darkness, weather, or time limit). The coaches should agree at the start of a particular inning that it is the "last declared inning." **While the 5-run rule is not in effect for the last inning, there is still a limit to scoring based on Rule 8.d. below (plus the D8 Interleague Rule) which sets a limit on the number of batters in an inning for a team.**

- b. The 15-Run (after 3 innings) and 10-Run (after 4 innings) mercy rules are followed (LL Green Book Rule).
- c. Teams in the lead by 5 or more runs are strongly encouraged to put on the brakes (i.e., advance only on a hit ball).
- d. Normally no batter may bat twice in the same inning (LL Green Book Rule).
 - i. **BUT** if two teams have unequal number of hitters and are batting continuous batting order, the max batters per inning is capped at whatever team has the greater number. For example, if one team has 9 batters and the other has 11, the team with 9 batters ends inning after the 11 batters (meaning two players can bat twice). (D8 Interleague Rule)

9. Umpires

- a. The Home team provides the home plate umpiring and may do so from behind the pitcher. The umpire should stand slightly offset from the pitcher to better judge the top and bottom of the strike zone, which for Little League is knees to armpits. Pay particular attention to where the catcher is positioned. Catchers often set up way too deep, and as such, pitches that are strikes may hit the ground first, and pitches that are too high will actually be caught with the appearance of being a strike. Encourage catchers to move forward to be closer to the batter to help remedy this issue.
- b. The Away team may provide a second umpire to cover first and second base. In such cases, the Home team umpire would cover third base and home plate.

10. Scorekeeping & Batting Order Tracking

- a. The Home team is responsible for keeping the official scorebook for the game, i.e., the scorebook of record. As such the home scorebook should track both batting orders, the batting results, the pitch counts, and the game score. The teams should provide each other with batting lineup information, so that both teams are able to keep score in a scorebook.